

The Influence of Governmental Trust, Media Use, and Partisanship on Public Support for Whistleblowers

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Introduction

This research paper seeks to investigate how partisanship, media use, and trust in government shape public support for whistleblowers who report government wrongdoing. Whistleblowers have become some of the most controversial figures in American politics. The public's reaction to these whistleblowers lies on a spectrum: some people see them as heroes defending democracy, while others view them as disloyal or politically motivated. These reactions raise sharp questions and concerns about the forces shaping how Americans judge whistleblowers. In an era marked by intense partisanship, fragmented media environments, and shifting levels of trust in government institutions, it is possible that people's political identities and information sources matter just as much as the details of the whistleblower's claims. This past June, Erez Reuveni, a DOJ veteran, came forward as a whistleblower to reveal violations of judicial power involving ignoring court orders for carrying out deportations. His disclosure helped trigger a federal crime-probe of a top executive of the agency, harnessing institutional accountability as a means of promoting transparency to the public (Thanawala, 2025). Understanding these dynamics is essential because whistleblowers play a major role in holding the government accountable, and public opinion can influence whether their disclosures lead to reform or backlash. To better understand the more recent factors shaping public support in the United States, this research paper will use the ANES (American National Election Studies) from the 2024 Pre-Election survey.

Literature Review

The term "whistleblowing" can reveal classified information that both harms public interest, and the potential to undermine a democratic system of governance. Whistleblowers themselves can be regarded as of service to the public good that can expose and prevent wrongdoing. It implies a legally protected and/or ethically justified release of information in order to hold accountability at the highest level. Framing can exert powerful effects on opinions, and as such, whether a person releasing documents is termed "whistleblower" or "leaker" should affect how they are viewed (Entman, 1993).

Certain partisan-motivated reasoning can impact public view and connection to whistleblower cases. Media headlines that disclose information against a political party can channel resentment and impact trust in partisanship affiliation. Specifically, framing a disclosure as injurious to one party should lead members of that party to view the disclosure more negatively than members of the opposing party (Touchton, M. R., Klostad, C. A., West, J. P., & Uscinski, J. E., 2020).

In line with public service motivation theory, public-sector employees are expected to be motivated to engage in whistle-blowing in response to motives inherent in public institutions such as following the rules and protecting the public interest such as norm-based and affective motives (Lavena, C. F., 2014). Norm-based motives such as patriotism, duty and loyalty can impact a worker's ability to act out of public interest while also adhering to their work motives. While revealing classified information risks termination for the employee, whistleblowing can be seen as an act of cooperation between citizens and the government.. Institutional mechanisms that have already established support in whistleblowing can lead to higher trust in government among public support (Antinyan, A., Corazzini, L., & Pavesi, F., 2020).

Research Question

The research question for this study plans to examine to what extent partisanship, media use, and trust in government shape public support for whistleblowers who report government wrongdoing.

The value of understanding public support for whistleblowers is crucial to understanding their role in protecting public interest. More pressure and coverage on whistleblowers can either negatively or positively influence the perception of their case. Without whistleblower activity, cooperation and healthy communication in public administration can become unnoticed and not regulated.

Furthermore, public support for whistleblowers is also a crucial component of democratic accountability. When individuals report government wrongdoing, the public's response can shape media coverage, institutional actions, and the legitimacy of subsequent investigations. Strong public support can empower whistleblowers and strengthen oversight, while weak support may discourage reporting and enable unethical behavior to persist. Examining how partisanship, media use, and trust in government shape attitudes toward whistleblowers provides insight into how citizens interpret allegations of public-sector misconduct and how democratic accountability functions in practice.

Hypothesis

The hypothesis that I plan to test for this study is represented as individuals with a higher trust in government institutions will show lower public support for whistleblowers who report government wrongdoing, while greater media use will be associated with higher support for whistleblowers.

This hypothesis is derived from other existing theories around institutional and political behavior. Individuals who trust government institutions may view whistleblowing as an accountability mechanism rather than a threat to authority.

Dataset

The data that I am using for this study comes from the American National Election Study (ANES) 2024 Pre-Election survey questionnaire, which analyzes public opinion and voting behavior during U.S presidential elections. The pre-election study was a multi-stage in-person sample targeting 232.5 million US citizens age 18 and over that resided in either of the 48 contiguous states. They use a probabilistic sampling method to ensure a wide range of age populations are included.

Most election study datasets do not explicitly ask their respondents about their feelings towards whistleblowers exposing wrongdoing. Finding the best suitable dataset for this project was more of a pull. However, ANES survey questions cover topics regarding citizens opinions of journalist access and mishandling classified information; all of which determine opinion of whistleblower support.

```
options(repos = c(CRAN = "https://cloud.r-project.org"))  
install.packages(c("tidyverse", "haven", "psych", "broom"))
```

```
Installing packages into 'C:/Users/delee/AppData/Local/R/win-library/4.4'  
(as 'lib' is unspecified)
```

```
package 'tidyverse' successfully unpacked and MD5 sums checked  
package 'haven' successfully unpacked and MD5 sums checked
```

```
Warning: cannot remove prior installation of package 'haven'
```

```
Warning in file.copy(savedcopy, lib, recursive = TRUE): problem copying  
C:\Users\delee\AppData\Local\R\win-library\4.4\00LOCK\haven\libs\x64\haven.dll  
to C:\Users\delee\AppData\Local\R\win-library\4.4\haven\libs\x64\haven.dll:  
Permission denied
```

```
Warning: restored 'haven'
```

```
package 'psych' successfully unpacked and MD5 sums checked  
package 'broom' successfully unpacked and MD5 sums checked
```

```
The downloaded binary packages are in  
C:\Users\delee\AppData\Local\Temp\RtmpmcBQ8C\downloaded_packages
```

```
library(tidyverse)
```

```
-- Attaching core tidyverse packages ----- tidyverse 2.0.0 --
v dplyr      1.1.4      v readr      2.1.5
v forcats    1.0.0      v stringr    1.5.1
v ggplot2    4.0.0      v tibble     3.2.1
v lubridate  1.9.4      v tidyr      1.3.1
v purrr      1.0.4
```

```
-- Conflicts ----- tidyverse_conflicts() --
x dplyr::filter() masks stats::filter()
x dplyr::lag()     masks stats::lag()
i Use the conflicted package (<http://conflicted.r-lib.org/>) to force all conflicts to become
```

```
library(haven)
library(psych)
```

Attaching package: 'psych'

The following objects are masked from 'package:ggplot2':

%,%, alpha

```
library(broom)
library(dplyr)

anes <- read.csv("anes_timeseries_2024_csv_20250808.csv")
```

The full ANES pre-election survey is a large dataset that contains 5,521 observations and 1722 variables.

Data Preprocessing

For this project, I will first clean the data to build proxies for the outcome variable (whistle-blower support). For this, I will use data from question V241333x described as the following: “Do you favor or oppose restricting journalist access?”. Response options are numerically assigned 1-7, 1 = Favor a great deal, 7 = Oppose a great deal. Additionally, I will also select question V241340 which states: “How likely would the following be to keep you from voting for a candidate that you otherwise liked? I.E the candidate mishandled top secret documents”. Response options for this question also range 1-5, 1 = Extremely likely, 5 = Not likely at all.

For readability, I named these variables `restrict_journalists`, and `mishandle_docs` to define what each question represents.

```
anes <- anes |>
select(
  # outcome proxies
  restrict_journalists = V241333x,      # 1-5; higher = support restrictions
  mishandle_docs = V241340,           # predictors
  trust_gov = V241229,                # trust in gov to do what is right
  party_id = V241221,                 # party identification DOES R THINK OF SELF AS D
  trust_news = V241335,               # trust in news media

  # media use
  sm_days = V242406,                  # days/week social media for news

  # demographics
  education = V245015

)                                     # 1-5 seriousness of mishandling docs
```

Next, I will select the predictor variables that I would want to use for this question. As stated earlier, this project seeks to examine how partisanship, media use and trust in government institutions play a role in shaping whistleblower support.

The first predictor variable I will select is trust in government, which the survey describes as: How often can you trust the federal government in Washington to do what is right? 1 = Always and 5 = Never. This variable will be called “`trust_gov`”.

The next variable is party affiliation, which is a demographic question in the survey that states “Does R think of self as Republican, Democrat or Independent?” This variable will be called “`party_id`”.

The next variable is trust in news, which will fall under media use. The question states: “In general, how much trust and confidence do you have in the news media when it comes to reporting the news fully, accurately and fairly? 1 = None, 5 = A great deal. This variable will be called “`trust_news`”.

Media use category will also include social media exposure, which the survey asks: “In a typical week, how many days did you use social media such as Facebook, Twitter, or X to follow news about parties and candidates? 0 = None/zero days, 7 = Seven days”. This variable will be called “`sm_days`”.

In the user codebook from the ANES website, all response options for every question include values (-9, -8 and -1) which indicate either (Refused, Don’t Know, or Inapplicable). To keep only the respondents that selected an option 1 -> 5, I recoded all numeric values to NA using an ifelse conditions.

After assigning survey question identifiers to variables, the predictor variables, `trust_gov`, `sm_days`, and `party_id`, were recoded to NA.

```
anes$trust_gov <- ifelse(anes$trust_gov %in% c(-9, -8, -1),
                        NA,
                        anes$trust_gov)

anes$sm_days <- ifelse(anes$sm_days %in% c(-9, -8, -1),
                      NA,
                      anes$sm_days)
anes$trust_news <- ifelse(anes$trust_news %in% c(-9, -8, -1),
                          NA,
                          anes$trust_news)
anes$party_id <- ifelse(anes$party_id %in% c(-9, -8, -1),
                       NA,
                       anes$party_id)
```

Variables of Interest

To summarize, here is a complete list of the variables of interest for this study, along with its question label from the ANES survey.

- **“trust_gov”** -> ordinal continuous variable. “How often can you trust the federal government in Washington to do what is right?” Options for responding are coded between 1-5. Higher numbers reflect progressively less trust: 1 = Always, 2 = Most of the time, 3 = About half of the time, 4 = Some of the time, 5 = Never, -9 = Refused, -8 = Don’t know, -1 = Not applicable.
- **“party_id”** -> ordinal categorical variable. Represents party affiliation for each respondent that they self-report during 2024. 0 = Strong Democrat, 1 = Not very strong Democrat, 2 = Independent but lean Democrat, 3 = Independent (pure independent/no lean), 4 = Independent, but lean Republican, 5 = Not very strong Republican, 6 = Strong Republican.
- **“sm_days”** -> ordinal variable. “In a typical week, how many days did you use social media such as Facebook, Twitter, or X to follow news about parties and candidates? 0 = None/zero days, 7 = Seven days”.
- **“trust_news”** -> ordinal continuous variable.”In general, how much trust and confidence do you have in the news media when it comes to reporting the news fully, accurately and fairly? 1 = None, 5 = A great deal.

Every year, the ANES dataset changes the direction of their response values (i.e if a respondent chooses “A great deal”, the numeric value is “1” instead of a higher number). The codebook for the 2024 pre-election survey calculates trust in government in reverse direction: 1 = Always,

5 = Never. In order to keep directionality consistent across the predictor variables, I reverse-coded trust in government so values 1 -> 5 indicates increasing trust.

```
anes <- anes |>
mutate(
  # reverse-code journalist restriction so higher = more support for transparency
  restrict_journalists_recode = case_when(
    restrict_journalists %in% 1:5 ~ 6 - restrict_journalists,
    TRUE ~ NA_real_),

  # convert party_id to numeric
  party_id = as.numeric(party_id),

  # reverse mishandling seriousness so higher = more support for accountability
  mishandle_docs_recode = case_when(
    mishandle_docs %in% 1:5 ~ mishandle_docs,
    TRUE ~ NA_real_
  ))

# reverse-code trust in government so 1 -> 5 means higher trust

anes$trust_gov <- 6 - anes$trust_gov
```

In order to maintain all predictor variables as numeric and continuous, I converted them all to numeric values by assigning “as.numeric” and variable name.

```
# continuous predictors

anes <- anes |>
mutate(Govt_Trust = as.numeric(trust_gov),
  News_Trust = as.numeric(trust_news),
  Social_Media_Use = as.numeric(sm_days),
  education = as.numeric(education),
)
```

After pulling out both restrict_journalist and mishandle_docs questions from the ANES survey, I created an index for whistleblower support by taking the means of the two questions.

To check for reliability, I calculated Cronbach’s alpha to observe the internal consistency, and notice if the two questions appear to measure whistleblower support. Because the scale only has two items, the resulting alpha is reported as a descriptive check and not as a strong indicator of reliability.

Using `scale()`, I then created an index combining the means `restrict_journalists_recode` + `mishandle_docs_recode`. I named this index `whistle_support`, as it displays the mean of support across the two outcome variables. I also converted the index to numeric, continuous variable.

```
whistle_vars <- anes |>
  select(restrict_journalists_recode, mishandle_docs_recode)

# Use library(psych) to run alpha check
alpha_whistleblower <- psych::alpha(whistle_vars)
alpha_whistleblower
```

Reliability analysis

Call: `psych::alpha(x = whistle_vars)`

raw_alpha	std.alpha	G6(smc)	average_r	S/N	ase	mean	sd	median_r
0.021	0.021	0.011	0.011	0.021	0.026	2.6	1.2	0.011

95% confidence boundaries

	lower	alpha	upper
Feldt	-0.03	0.02	0.07
Duhachek	-0.03	0.02	0.07

Reliability if an item is dropped:

	raw_alpha	std.alpha	G6(smc)	average_r	S/N
<code>restrict_journalists_recode</code>	0.0091	0.011	0.00011	0.011	0.011
<code>mishandle_docs_recode</code>	0.0124	0.011	0.00011	0.011	0.011

	alpha	se	var.r	med.r
<code>restrict_journalists_recode</code>	NA	0	0.011	
<code>mishandle_docs_recode</code>	NA	0	0.011	

Item statistics

	n	raw.r	std.r	r.cor	r.drop	mean	sd
<code>restrict_journalists_recode</code>	2316	0.66	0.71	0.073	0.011	2.6	1.1
<code>mishandle_docs_recode</code>	5221	0.90	0.71	0.073	0.011	2.6	1.3

Non missing response frequency for each item

	1	2	3	4	5	miss
<code>restrict_journalists_recode</code>	0.08	0.63	0.04	0.15	0.10	0.58
<code>mishandle_docs_recode</code>	0.29	0.20	0.25	0.14	0.12	0.05


```
# Create index (mean of standardized items)
anes$whistle_index <- scale(anes$restrict_journalists_recode) +
                        scale(anes$mishandle_docs_recode)
anes$whistle_index <- as.numeric(anes$whistle_index)
```

From the table, restrict_journalists has way less observations than mishandle_docs, thus weakening any sign of overlap between the two scales. The two items contain some internal consistency, with raw.r (not standardized) at a level that shows some relation to the combined index. Although there is a lower inter-item correlation, for this study I am treating it as a exploratory measure of whistleblower public support.

Descriptive Statistics

The new, cleaned dataset now has 5,521 rows and 17 columns.

```
dim(anes)
```

```
[1] 5521    13
```

```
head(anes)
```

	restrict_journalists	mishandle_docs	trust_gov	party_id	trust_news	sm_days
1	6	3	1	2	1	7
2	4	5	1	5	2	0
3	7	4	2	1	3	7
4	2	5	2	2	3	0
5	3	2	1	3	1	1
6	6	1	2	3	3	0

	education	restrict_journalists_recode	mishandle_docs_recode	Govt_Trust
1	-1	NA	3	1
2	-1	2	5	1
3	-1	NA	4	2
4	-1	4	5	2
5	-1	3	2	1
6	-1	NA	1	2

	News_Trust	Social_Media_Use	whistle_index
1	1	7	NA
2	2	0	1.30648391
3	3	7	NA
4	3	0	3.04678309
5	1	1	-0.05614207
6	3	0	NA

```
summary(anes$whistle_support)
```

```
Length Class Mode
      0  NULL  NULL
```

```
summary(anes[, c("Govt_Trust", "party_id", "Social_Media_Use",
                  "News_Trust", "education")])
```

Govt_Trust	party_id	Social_Media_Use	News_Trust
Min. :1.000	Min. :0.000	Min. :-7.000	Min. :1.000
1st Qu.:2.000	1st Qu.:1.000	1st Qu.: 0.000	1st Qu.:2.000
Median :2.000	Median :2.000	Median : 0.000	Median :2.000
Mean :2.441	Mean :2.019	Mean : 1.683	Mean :2.447
3rd Qu.:3.000	3rd Qu.:3.000	3rd Qu.: 5.000	3rd Qu.:3.000
Max. :5.000	Max. :5.000	Max. : 7.000	Max. :5.000
NA's :23	NA's :274	NA's :255	NA's :268

education
Min. :-9.0000
1st Qu.: -1.0000
Median : -1.0000
Mean : -0.5686
3rd Qu.: -1.0000
Max. : 9.0000

Directed Acyclic Graph (DAG)

To better visualize the casual relationship between media, government and news trust, a DAG was drawn as a representation of the hypothesis testing discussed previously. The outcome variable, `whistle_support`, combined as a numeric index from `restrict_journalists` (Should journalists be restricted from accessing government information?) and `mishandle_docs_rev` (How likely to keep you from voting for a candidate that mishandled top-secret documents or classified information?). The predictor variables used in the DAG are social media use, trust in government institutions, trust in news outlets, and party affiliation. Trust in government impacts the overall score of whistleblower support, which is affected by `party_id`, social media use and trust in news outlets.

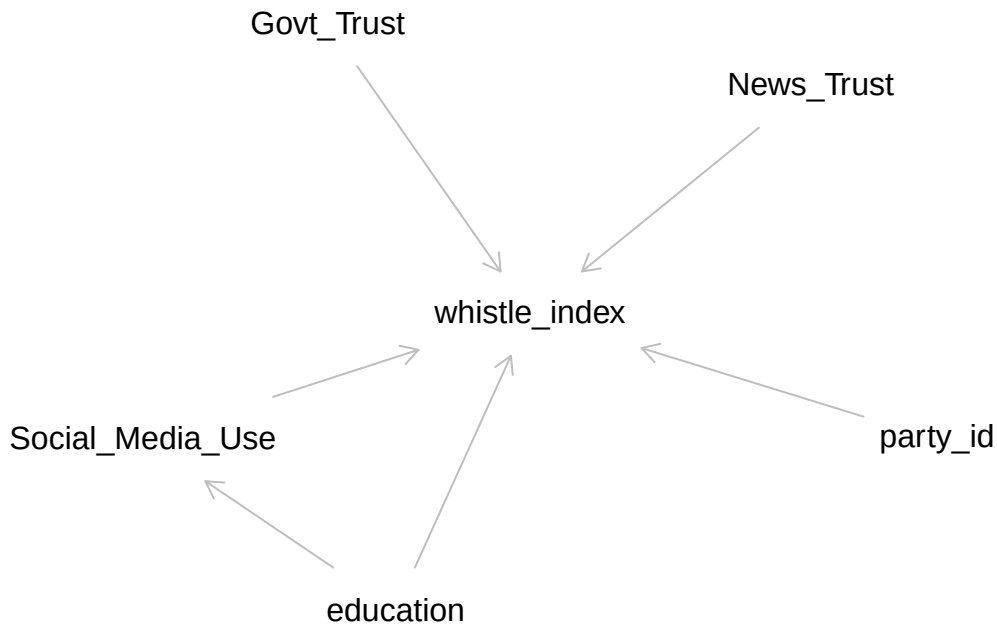
Moreover, demographic information such as education level are also included to recognize the potential confounding influences on government trust and social media. People with less education may reliable more on social media use, which impacts there overall exposure to whistleblowers in the news. Education level has a direct impact on social media use, which can indirectly affect whistleblower support.

This research paper will use a multiple regression model to test which predictive factors has the strongest impact on the mean of whistleblower support and opinion. Other casual relationships visualized in the DAG will be further analyzed for its association to whistleblower support.

```
library(dagitty)

dag <- dagitty ('
  dag {
    party_id -> whistle_index
    Social_Media_Use -> whistle_index
    News_Trust -> whistle_index
    Govt_Trust -> whistle_index
    education -> Social_Media_Use
    education -> whistle_index
  }
')
```

```
dag |> graphLayout() |> plot()
```



Hypothesis Testing

The hypothesis for this study states that individuals who reported higher trust in government institutions will show lower support for whistleblowers who report government wrongdoing, as their behavior is deemed to be unloyal or indutiful to their public service. Greater media use will be associated with higher support for whistleblowers, as more exposure to reported

scandals and political corruption would cause positive opinions of employees who expose wrongdoing.

The fitted multiple linear regression model below uses the outcome and predictor variables recoded from 2024 ANES dataset and controls for demographic information such as age, gender, and educational level of the respondent. These demographics will be included in the model to account for any independent differences in whistleblowers (i.e older people might be more or less supportive of whistleblowers). Additionally, it will help in reducing cofounders that otherwise would not be controlled for if testing just the 4 main predictors. The regression model is labelled as “mod1” to represent it as the single model for this project.

```
mod1 <- lm(
  whistle_index ~ Govt_Trust + Social_Media_Use + News_Trust +
    party_id + education,
  data = anes
)

summary(mod1)
```

Call:

```
lm(formula = whistle_index ~ Govt_Trust + Social_Media_Use +
    News_Trust + party_id + education, data = anes)
```

Residuals:

Min	1Q	Median	3Q	Max
-3.0916	-1.0523	-0.1587	0.9570	4.5393

Coefficients:

	Estimate	Std. Error	t value	Pr(> t)
(Intercept)	0.525795	0.128623	4.088	4.50e-05 ***
Govt_Trust	-0.054014	0.033128	-1.630	0.10314
Social_Media_Use	-0.013698	0.007721	-1.774	0.07619 .
News_Trust	-0.202821	0.030188	-6.719	2.31e-11 ***
party_id	0.085898	0.032056	2.680	0.00742 **
education	0.003918	0.012119	0.323	0.74650

Signif. codes: 0 '***' 0.001 '**' 0.01 '*' 0.05 '.' 0.1 ' ' 1

Residual standard error: 1.401 on 2280 degrees of freedom

(3235 observations deleted due to missingness)

Multiple R-squared: 0.03472, Adjusted R-squared: 0.03261

F-statistic: 16.4 on 5 and 2280 DF, p-value: 6.201e-16

```
confint(mod1)
```

	2.5 %	97.5 %
(Intercept)	0.27356373	0.778025697
Govt_Trust	-0.11897901	0.010950497
Social_Media_Use	-0.02883951	0.001443417
News_Trust	-0.26201881	-0.143622763
party_id	0.02303507	0.148760189
education	-0.01984693	0.027682857

```
mod1$coefficients
```

(Intercept)	Govt_Trust	Social_Media_Use	News_Trust
0.525794713	-0.054014259	-0.013698048	-0.202820784
party_id	education		
0.085897629	0.003917965		

Interpretation

Based on the summary output from the regression, these are what the coefficients reveal:

Trust in Government Institutions -> The question from the pre-election survey pertaining to trust in Washington were coded 1-5, with higher numbers indicating less trust in government. After holding all demographic variables constant, having less trust in government is associated with 0.05 increase support for whistleblowers to report government wrongdoing. Individuals that have more trust in government institutions to do what is right will have less support for whistleblowers. The confidence interval for trust in government is between -0.11 and 0.01 and contains a true zero, meaning there is no clear effect in the relationship. The reported p-value is also 0.10, meaning that this relationship is not statistically significant. This indicates that trust in government institutions and whistleblower support are statistically insignificant.

Social Media Use -> From the regression model, the reported coefficient for social media use per week is -0.0136, indicating that there is a slightly negative relationship between social media use and support for whistleblowers. As media use increases, whistleblower support decreases only marginally by -0.0136. The reported confidence interval between -0.02 and 0.002 contains a true zero, meaning that there is no clear effect either between social media use and whistleblower support. The p-value is also reported as 0.07. Therefore, the relationship between social media use and whistleblower support is statistically insignificant as well.

Trust in News -> From the regression model, the reported coefficient for trust in news is -0.20, indicating a strong negative impact. Individuals that have greater trust in their news outlets will tend to have less support for whistleblowers, which is an interesting yet counterintuitive result that deserves further exploration. The confidence interval for this coefficient is between

-0.26 and -0.14, meaning that there is a clear negative effect. The p-value of $2.31e-11$ means an extremely small p-value that the null hypothesis can be rejected, and that trust in news is statistically significant.

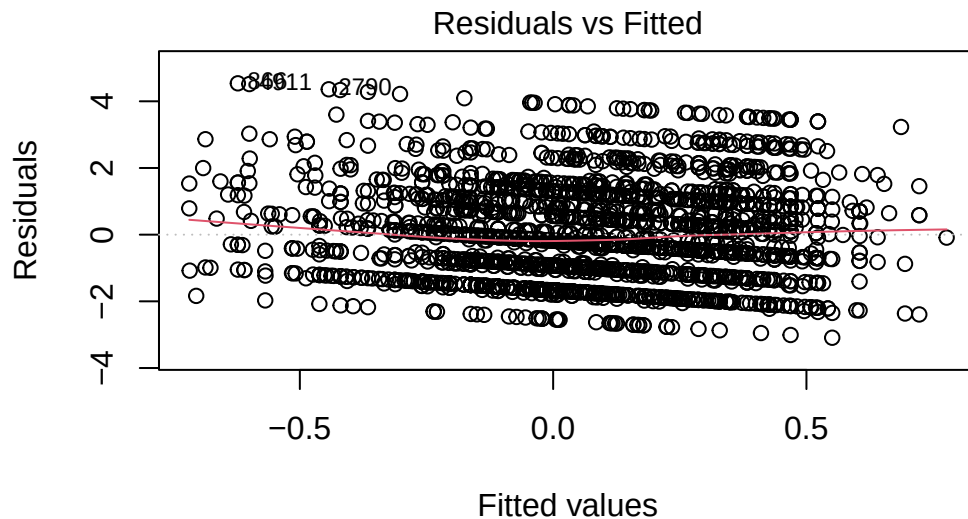
Party_ID -> Based on the regression model, party_id reported 0.0858 coefficient, indicating that party affiliation has a more positive association with more support for whistleblowers. The reported p-value was 0.009, making it quite statistically significant to reject the null hypothesis. The confidence interval of 0.023 to 0.14 suggests a strong relationship that partisanship does matter in public support.

To summarize, the hypothesis test for this study proposed that individuals who have higher trust in their government institutions will likely have higher support for whistleblowers. After running the regression model, the regression results do not support this hypothesis. The confidence interval for Govt_Trust ranged from -0.119 to 0.011, crossing zero, indicating that the effect of government trust on whistleblower support is not statistically significant. This study accepts the null hypothesis, and that the data does not provide evidence that higher trust in government is associated with increased support for whistleblowers.

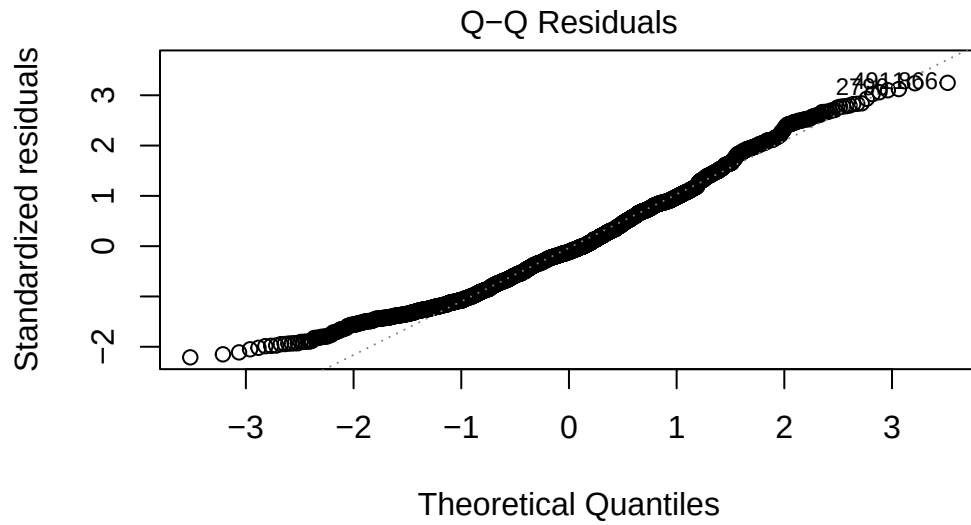
In contrast, other predictive factors showed more defined associations. Partisanship had a positive and significant effect on support, while trust in news was negatively associated with support. Social media use and education did not show significant effects.

Diagnostic and Model Fitting

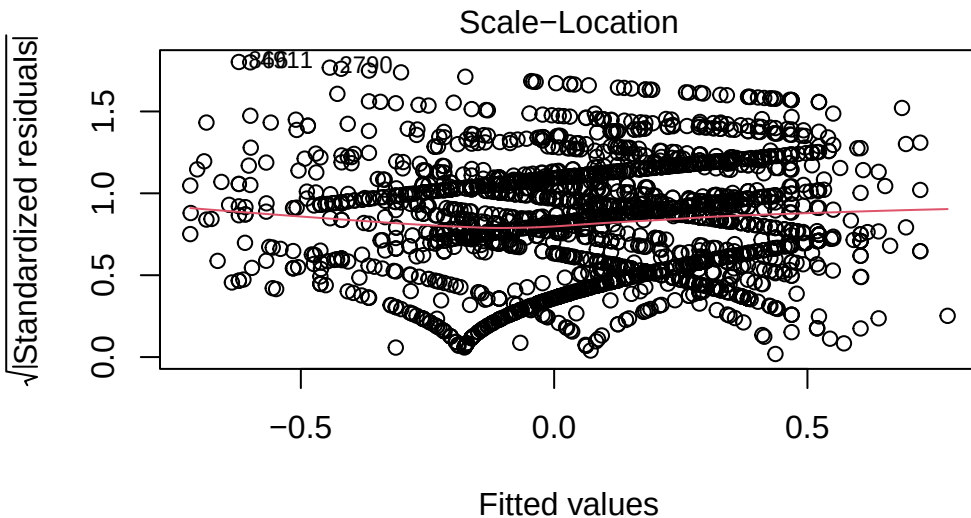
```
plot(mod1)
```



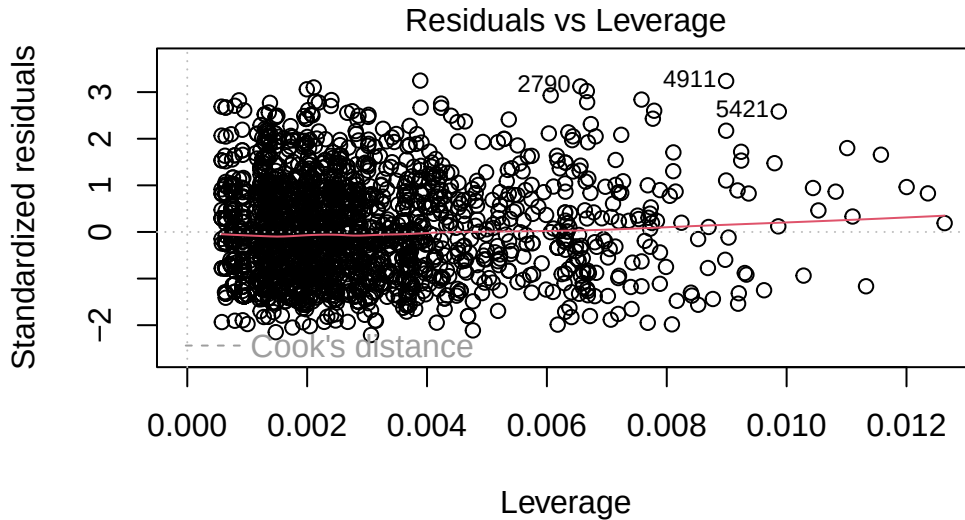
m(whistle_index ~ Govt_Trust + Social_Media_Use + News_Trust + party_i



m(whistle_index ~ Govt_Trust + Social_Media_Use + News_Trust + party_i



m(whistle_index ~ Govt_Trust + Social_Media_Use + News_Trust + party_i



In the Residuals vs. Fitted plot, the points are fairly consistent throughout the graph and don't suggest a heteroskedasticity situation. Some outliers at point 4 and -4 are present, but could be due to the large sample size from the survey. The line has some curvature in the middle, suggesting that there is a mild violation of the linearity assumption with a few points considered as outliers. Given the discrete nature of the outcome variable (combined likert scale measures into whistleblower support), these observations and deviations are expected.

In the Q-Q Residuals plot, the residuals track along the diagonal line, showing that they are normally distributed. There are slight tails and deviations at both ends of the lines, possibly due to the large sample size from the survey.

In the Scale Location plot, the line remains mostly horizontal, but contains a slight dip in the middle, suggesting only a mild violation of homoskedasticity. The points at 2790 and 4911 are outliers. For the most part, the points on the graph are fairly constant and any observed deviation is only minor.

In the Cook's distance plot, most of the observations have very low leverage. On the right side of the plot, there are a few high-leverage points, but they do not cross the Cook's distance line. The red line has a slightly downward trend, which shows that the higher leverage observations are not driving the model's predictions. In conclusion, there is no evidence of highly influential observations, since all points fall within the Cook's distance line.

All the model diagnostic plots suggest the linear assumptions are reasonably met, but are not perfect. The residual points are consistently centered around zero, and no major variance suggests any strong indicator of a heteroskedasticity problem. Furthermore, all residuals points

are observed to be normally distributed and no influential observations are detected. While some minor deviations are present, this could open the door for future exploratory analysis in testing each individual survey item instead of a combined index. Overall, these results indicate that the regression model supports valid claims about whistleblower support.

```
adj_r2 <- summary(mod1)$adj.r.squared  
adj_r2
```

```
[1] 0.03260592
```

The reported adjusted r-squared from this model is 0.0326. Since this value is close to 0, it is evidence that the predictive factors and whistleblower support is weak. 3.26% of the variation is explained in whistleblower support after accounting for the predictors in the model. This result suggests that factors such as partisanship, media use, and trust in government institutions have a limited extent in influencing public support for whistleblowers that expose wrongdoing. Other attitudes may also influence support, but future research can work to include models that analyze each individual factor in relation to the whistleblower index.

Conclusion

The results from the regression show that party affiliation has the biggest effect on public support for whistleblowers that expose wrongdoing. Additionally, individuals who have greater trust in their news outlets will have less support for whistleblowers that expose wrongdoing. This study concluded in accepting the null hypothesis that higher trust in government institutions. Social media use and education level does not have any effect on public attitudes around whistleblowers either. These findings overall provide insight into the value of media perception and party identification shape opinions about whistleblowers and their actions.

The low adjusted R-squared value demonstrates that the model is weak in nature, and suggests that other influences and factors may associate themselves better with whistleblower support.

Future research and analysis could explore how age and income dimensions factor into overall trust in government and trust in news. If there was more time, I would be interested in delving into `mishandle_docs` as one outcome variable, and running a regression with `party_id` and `trust_news` to see if the outputs are similar.

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